ATKINSON ELEMENTARY · SPANISH DUAL LANGUAGE IMMERSION · OCTOBER 2026

Atkinson is a Thriving, Diverse School Community

Atkinson is an example of a well-resourced school that is currently serving 21% multilingual learners and 44% historically underserved learners.

Student snapshot, October 2025	Whole school	DLI program
Students	366	178 (49% of school)
Historically underserved students	161 (44%)	71%
Multilingual learners	78 (21%)	40%

Atkinson immersion is in demand

In the 2026-27 kindergarten lottery, Atkinson had the **longest waitlist of any PPS immersion program** and the most applications of any Spanish program (only Richmond's Japanese program had more). Over 5 years, it averaged about 5 applications for every seat offered (121 vs 24). Lent waitlisted 13 applicants in 2026-27.

Kindergarten lottery	Offered	Waitlisted	Applications
2026-27	25	47 (14 native and heritage)	125
2025-26	23	53 (10 native and heritage)	113
2024-25	24	47 (21 native and heritage)	114

Native and heritage = children who speak Spanish at home or in the family. A family can be on more than one waitlist.

Central site vs. edge site

- Atkinson is 1.8 miles from the district edge. Lent is 0.3 miles from it.
- Two in three Atkinson immersion students (118 of 178) already come from outside Atkinson's neighborhood.
- Their trip to school would grow about 1 mile on average (estimate from PPS home-neighborhood data).
- Across PPS, the share of Spanish-speaking children (ages 5-17) living within 1 mile of a Spanish immersion school drops from about 52% to 36% under either scenario.

Who moves, and what changes at Atkinson

- Atkinson's immersion program is 70% Latino. Its neighborhood program is 8% Latino and 76% white.
- PPS's own guide projects Atkinson after the move: historically underserved students 44% to 21%; multilingual learners 21% to 7%; poverty 32% to 23%.
- Racial separation among Southeast schools (Atkinson, Lent, Creston) rises: the Latino-white dissimilarity index goes from 0.35 to 0.58 (0 = evenly mixed, 1 = fully separate).
- Lent's school grounds are about 120 feet from I-205. Atkinson is 1.5 miles from the nearest freeway.

What happened last time: Bridger to Lent (2023)

- Lent now enrolls 31% fewer immersion kindergartners than Bridger and Lent did together before the move. The district fell 14% over the same period.
- PPS's 2023 plan projected 527 students at Lent for 2025-26. Lent has 256, in a building for about 798 (32% full).
- PPS's new guides expect only about 4 in 5 Atkinson immersion students to follow the program to Lent.

Our concerns about Scenarios A and B

- **Equity.** Furthers segregation as an unintended consequence; increases vulnerability of an already frightened community; removes choice for ESL students; worsens environmental injustice.
- **Enrollment.** Demand could fill a second DLI kindergarten class, drawing families from across the city; NH DLI families overwhelmingly say they won't transfer to Lent; Lent remains under-enrolled despite PPS's projections.
- **Community.** A diverse school community is an asset to all students; Atkinson's central Southeast location makes it reachable for native and heritage families from outside the neighborhood; walking and biking are a priority for Atkinson families.
- **Process.** Is four weeks really enough time to address the concerns of thousands of parents? Incomplete transition plans are unacceptable.

Questions for Director Engleman

1. After the Bridger move, Lent lost families beyond the district trend. What will PPS do differently to keep Atkinson families?
2. Every projection for Lent has been too high (527 planned, 256 actual). Why is the new 400+ projection more reliable?
3. Will PPS provide bus service from the Atkinson area to Lent? Busing plans so far are shown only for North Portland.
4. Has PPS measured air quality at Lent, next to I-205? What filtration or other protections are planned?
5. Can current Atkinson immersion students and their younger siblings finish at Atkinson? What is the timeline?
6. PPS's guide says Lent with Atkinson's program meets the size goal but not the space goal. What does that mean?
7. Did PPS study keeping a central Southeast Spanish immersion site?

What we ask

> Pause the process to allow deep engagement with PPS families and revision of the proposals.
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> Explore creative solutions like moving Creston students to Glencoe (suggested at a recent district meeting).

Sources: PPS 2026-27 Kindergarten Lottery Results and 2022-23 to 2026-27 lottery reports; PPS School Profiles dashboard (2025); PPS Enrollment Summary by Race and Ethnicity and Language Immersion Track Profiles (Oct 2025); PPS rightsizing school guides for Atkinson and Lent (Oct 8, 2026); PPS Enrollment by Neighborhood of Residence; PSU enrollment forecasts; PPS Southeast Guiding Coalition equity audit; U.S. Census ACS (C16001/B16007); OpenStreetMap. Analysis: pps-dli-explorer.netlify.app (independent; builds on pps-explorer by Jason Brown and ppsdata.info). Distances and the 1-mile trip increase are estimates; see the site's Methods page.